

DHANUJ ACHU

CINEMA ▲

Celluloid Dreams

***Piyush Thakur*'s National Award-winning *The First Film* is his heartfelt tribute to cinema**

In a small town in 1960s India, where cinema is forbidden for women, a 14-year-old embarks on a quest to watch her first film. That is the premise of *The First Film*, a short by filmmaker Piyush Thakur, which went on to win the Golden Lotus for Best Direction and the Silver Lotus for Best Music Direction at the 71st National Film Awards recently. "It took a while to sink in," says the director. "More than pride, I felt gratitude—for all the people who stood by me through the long years this film took."

Having resonated with audiences across the world, it was but natural for the movie to create a buzz in India. "At its core, *The First Film* is not just about cinema—it's about longing, friendship and the courage to dream. Whether someone is watching it in Moscow, Stuttgart or Texas, they can connect with the feeling of wanting something deeply, and the small acts of bravery it takes to reach for it."

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With a firm belief that cinema is a "shared love language", Thakur reflects on how the collective joy of the movie-going experience transcends boundaries. "The smell of popcorn or samosas, the anticipation of watching your favourite star, the shared emotions in a dark hall—these belong to people everywhere. Since *The First Film* celebrates that very spirit, maybe that's why it has connected so strongly across borders," he concludes. ■

—Deepa Natarajan Lobo

MUSIC ▼

CONFLUENCE OF **SOUNDS**

Guitarists Abhay Nayampally and Arenlong Longkumer's new album *Treekam* blends Carnatic ragas and Naga chants with jazz elements

For music composer and producer Sandeep Chowta, the journey of the new instrumental album *Treekam* started with "a desire to say something that can't be said within the boundaries of any one genre". The five-track album released on Chowta's Namma Music label features Carnatic guitarist Abhay Nayampally and Naga guitarist Arenlong Longkumer. Also on the album are American drummer Jerrod 'J-rod' Sullivan, British bassist Seb Read and the legendary keyboardist and member of the jazz band Spyro Gyra, Tom Schuman. Two tracks, composed by Longkumer, also showcase chants by Naga singer-songwriter Mengu Suokhrie and the Nagaland Folkloric Group.

The album name *Treekam* comes from the Sanskrit word *trikam*, meaning the confluence of three. It's a metaphor for



Chowta's vision for the album—"Building a new musical lexicon where a *tanam* [rhythmic improvisation in Carnatic] can flow into a jazz walking bass line, and a Naga folk melody can become the head for a jazz standard." The challenge, of course, was to combine them seamlessly. "I don't think there has been an album like this before that blends Carnatic, Naga and jazz sounds. Melodically, it's not a very complex album and that was a conscious decision," explains Nayampally. He has composed three tracks on the album—'Divine Directions, 'Swan Song' and 'Spunky Town'. 'Swan Song', based on raga Hamsadhwani, reunited him with Barcelona-based Schuman. The duo has previously collaborated on the 13-time Grammy-nominated keyboardist's 2024 solo album, *I Am Schuman*.

Based in Mokokchung, Longkumer describes himself as the 'odd man' on the album. "Everyone else is classically oriented and has played a lot of jazz music. I am primarily a rock 'n' roll guitarist," he says. An M.Phil in Linguistics, his compositions blend progressive rock, metal and Naga folk music. Carnatic music was just as new to Longkumer as jazz, but his goal for *Treekam* was to "fuse two distinct sounds into one entity". Apart from translating traditional Naga music to the guitar, Longkumer's compositions also feature chants from Ao and Lotha tribes. ■

—Karishma Upadhyay